

at Actium in western Greece in 31 BCE, Octavian became the master of the Roman world.

Rome's first emperor

Octavian returned to Rome in 28 BCE and, instead of following Caesar's example, he renounced the dictatorial powers granted to him in order to wage his war against Antony. In 27 BCE, in gratitude for his service to Rome, the Senate bestowed on him the name Augustus ("revered personage") and granted him wide-ranging legal powers. Eventually, through political sleight of hand, he became Rome's sole ruler, controlling all aspects of the Roman state and command of the army.

An emperor in all but name (he was careful to spurn such titles, styling himself instead as princeps, or "first citizen"), over the next four decades, Augustus set about transforming the ruins of the republican system into an imperial autocracy, all the while maintaining the illusion that his authority was dependent on the will of the people. He loosely established the boundaries of the empire, pushed through reforms to clean up both private and public life, and crushed dissent. After the long periods of exhausting civil war, many in the empire were grateful for peace.

The Pax Romana

Indeed the might of the Roman military and the consequent improvements in security and stability across a vast stretch of territory, in what became known as the Pax Romana ("Roman Peace"), led to a growth in trade, economic activity, population, and general prosperity. The arts and culture flourished, public and private building works proliferated, and the provinces outside Italy underwent a process of Romanization, in which the Roman language, culture, laws, and institutions were embedded into diverse societies and across ethnic boundaries. Provincials were even granted full Roman citizenship after a period of military service.

However, for the regions beyond the bounds of empire, Augustus's Pax Romana often meant just the opposite. Even after reducing the army from 80 legions to a



The Ara Pacis Augustae altar in Rome is dedicated to Pax, the Roman goddess of peace. The processional frieze shows members of the Roman Senate with a priest.

permanent force of just 28, Augustus had to find employment for 150,000 soldiers. He launched a series of campaigns to extend borders, suppress and harry rebels and "barbarians," and enslave people from conquered areas.

An imperial legacy

By the end of his life in 14 CE, Augustus had established a new imperial system that would endure for centuries. For some years before his death, Augustus had prepared the way for an heir to succeed him, and retain control of the state. His step-son Tiberius was gradually granted powers until he could effectively be considered to be a co-emperor. This smoothed the transition of authority on Augustus' death, preventing a vacuum of power and ensuring continuity.

Augustus thus established the principle of direct succession and ensured the survival of the office of emperor. The system continued through multiple dynasties, with the empire reaching its height under the Nerva-Antonine dynasty when the emperor Hadrian ordered the building of a wall in northern Britain to mark the empire's outer limit.

The transition from republic to monarchy, while drastic, gave Rome a new stability. Masquerading as a democrat, Augustus created a new autocratic system of government, which, despite restricting political participation, was much better able to resist the compulsive upheavals that had plagued the Roman Republic a generation before. ■